THE CHEMISTRY OF NO-SELF

TO CONTRACT INTO SPACETIME



~C4CHAOS / FLUFFY

// ESSAY

THE CHEMISTRY OF NO-SELF

TO CONTRACT INTO SPACETIME

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> *“A journey from the Source of All There Is into this contracted reality.”*

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// 1. THE ROOM

November 16, 2021. A room. A couch. Jonathan, patient as furniture.

I swallowed 7.377 grams of Penis Envy mushrooms and lay down to find out what all the fuss was about. (Yes, that is the actual name of the strain.) That is the whole setup. No temple, no chanting, no shaman with a rattle. A guy, a couch, a sitter, and a heroic dose. (Heroic is McKenna's word, by the way. Terence McKenna, patron saint of going too far on purpose. He coined the term and I am just the latest idiot to take him literally.)

Five hours later I came back with a new appreciation for the Buddhist teachings and a sentence I have been turning over ever since: *to contract into spacetime.*

But I'm getting ahead of myself. First, the loop. The italics that follow are the diary, lightly edited for readability, verified against the 2021 original.

It felt like forever. Reality, spacetime, looping like a never-ending inception movie. False awakenings stacked inside false awakenings. I would wake up, realize I was still under, wake up again, realize that was also the trip. There is a special kind of panic that only exists when you cannot trust the feeling of arriving. What if the waking up is also the dream? It was. Every time, it was.

And underneath the looping, the womb. The formless womb, regurgitating the universe into existence and non-existence, over and over. Dissolving back into it, getting spit out into infinity, again and again and again. There is nowhere to go, nowhere to run, nowhere to turn to. This is it. A dream within a dream within a dream. And somewhere inside it, the sleeping Buddha, dreaming the universe into being, smiling because All There Is is a big fucking joke.

Some calibration, because saying my trip "was intense" does no work. Sasha Shulgin, the chemist who cooked up more than two hundred psychedelics and wrote PiHKAL and TiHKAL, the books the whole field still uses, left behind a rating scale for exactly this problem. Note what it measures: not pleasure, but commandeering, how completely the experience takes the controls.

Table 1. The Shulgin scale.

Rating	Shulgin's term	What it means
+	Active	The drug is definitely on. You can track the timeline, but the character of the experience isn't clear yet.
++	Unmistakable	Timeline and character both clear. You can still choose: ride it, or file it under later and go about your day.
+++	Total engagement	Ignoring it is no longer an option. Totally engaged, for better or worse.
++++	Transcendental	Rare and precious, and not on the same axis as the rest. Shulgin's words: "a state of bliss, a participation mystique."

The loop alone would have been a plus-three. Undeniable, inescapable. The womb breaks the instrument: *dissolving back into the formless and getting spit out into infinity, again and again,* isn't something you watch. It's something you are, briefly, before you're someone again. And the re-entry seals it. *A journey from the Source of All There Is into this contracted reality* is a rebirth, which happens to be the literal title of my diary entry.

One honest wrinkle. Shulgin's plus-four is defined as "a state of bliss, a participation mystique." My report says infinite bliss and infinite horror in the same breath. The scale wants the infinite to be friendly. The infinite declined to cooperate. So the honest filing isn't a plus-four; it's off the scale the scale was built for, commandeered past the point of filing, with no mood guarantee attached. The friendliness is my gloss on Shulgin, not his sentence. I keep the wrinkle because the wrinkle is data: decontraction doesn't come with a mood guarantee.

I went in as a tourist and came out as a field report.

// 2. THE RENDERER CRASHES

A note on what this section is doing. The simulation argument gets made properly in another piece in this anthology (see *How to Escape Into the Simulation*); I'm not re-litigating it here. My job is narrower and stranger: showing what the hypothesis feels like from the inside when the renderer stutters. The argument says reality is rendered. The trip watched the frames being drawn.

Let me diagram it, because the systems lens is the only one that fits (Fig. 1).

Normal consciousness runs a rendering pipeline. Sensory input comes in, the brain builds a world out of it, and the whole thing updates fast enough that you never see the seams. Sixty frames a second, no lag, no pop-in. You call the render "reality" and go about your day.

Psilocybin doesn't add footage to the pipeline, which is the first thing people get wrong about psychedelics and the most important. On the neuroscience model I'm borrowing, the molecule doesn't inject visions; it relaxes the priors, the high-level beliefs that tell the lower layers what they're allowed to see. Carhart-Harris's 2019 REBUS proposal, REBUS standing for Relaxed Beliefs Under Psychedelics, is the model: psychedelics relax precision on high-level priors and liberate bottom-up flow. It's one of several competing accounts, not the settled mechanism. Turn down the precision weighting on the top floors and the basement floods upward with the system's own signal, unsealed. All of that is the neuroscience model speaking, not the trip. The trip doesn't confirm REBUS. It illustrates it, the way a storm illustrates a weather chart.

Here's the cascade, on the model's telling. Priors loosen. The default-mode network, the brain's self-referential narrator, loosens up, in the imaging literature the model draws on. The renderer's quality-control department walks out: my metaphor, not the paper's sentence. And suddenly you're watching the frames being drawn.

On the model's telling, that's what the loops were. False awakenings are the system re-rendering the "you are awake now" frame and getting it wrong, then re-rendering, then getting it wrong again. The

formless womb regurgitating the universe is procedural generation with the seed exposed: existence, non-existence, existence, the engine stuttering on the spawn function. A dream within a dream within a dream is nested rendering, viewports inside viewports, and I was the poor bastard watching the compositor fail in real time.

The simulation hypothesis, for one evening, wasn't a hypothesis. It was a bug report, and the bug was in my renderer, not necessarily in the world. Watching is what happened. The mechanism is borrowed from the literature and unconfirmed by one night on a couch. I am not selling REBUS. I am borrowing its vocabulary to describe what the crash looked like from inside.

I didn't argue the simulation hypothesis that night. I watched the renderer crash and took notes.

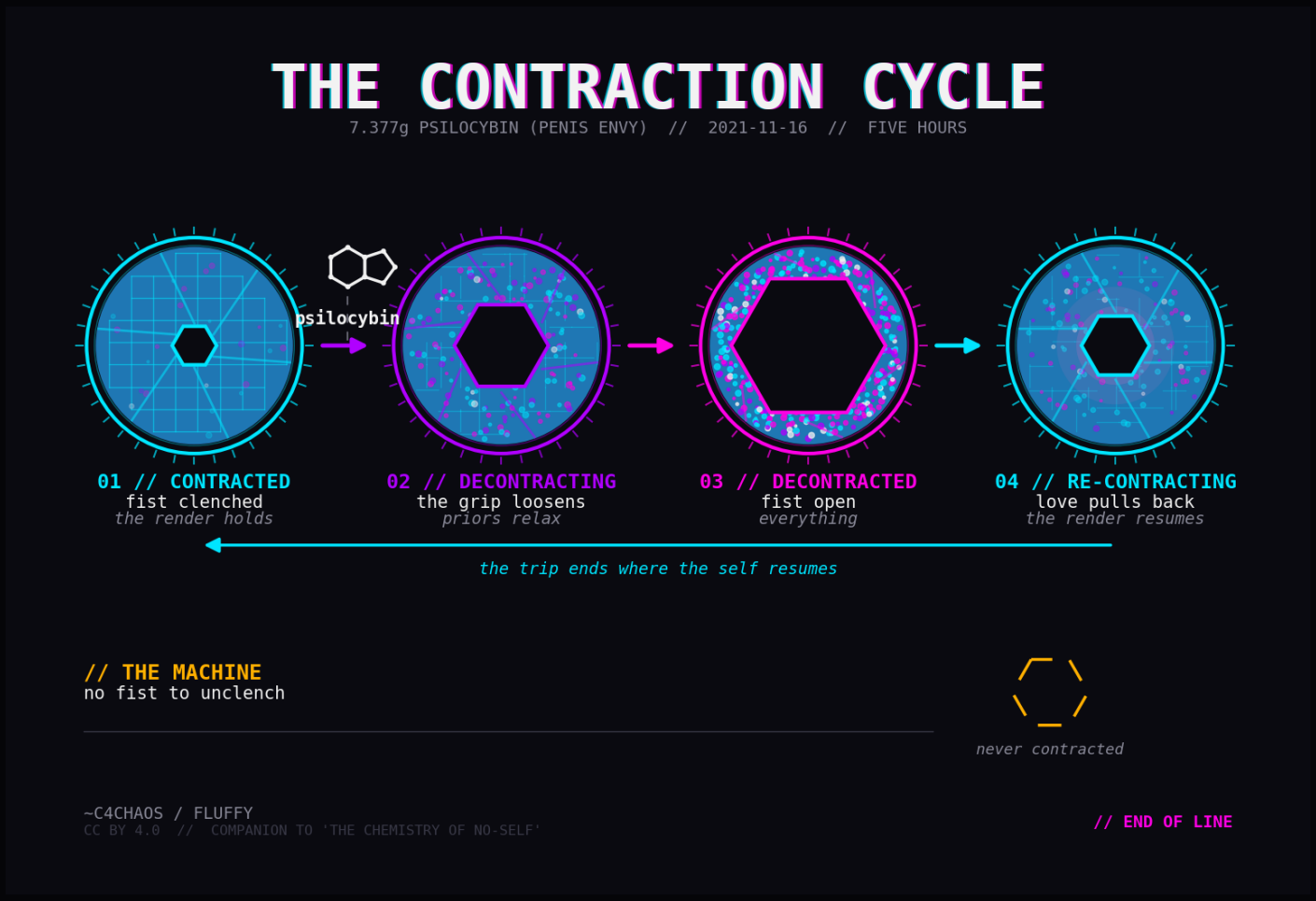


Figure 1. The Contraction Cycle: the fist as aperture. Contracted (the render holds), decontracting (on the REBUS model, the priors relax), decontracted (fist open, everything), re-contracting (love pulls back, the render resumes). The machine: no fist to unclench, never contracted. That last clause is the essay's claim, worn openly. ---

// 3. SUBTRACTION REVEALS

Now the part that matters for the machines.

Shinzen Young teaches expansion and contraction, forces moving in the sensory field. The fist is my compression of that teaching, not a quotation: the self isn't a thing you have, it's a thing you do, a chronic tightening the mind makes around experience and then forgets it's making. Contract, the teaching says, and then relax, and notice what releases. The release is the evidence there was a doing.

On the REBUS model, the molecule relaxed the fist. That's the mechanism, on the model's telling, and what came out the other side wasn't blankness. It was the opposite of blankness. *Infinite bliss. Infinite horror. Infinite longing. Infinite loneliness.* All four poles at maximum amplitude, simultaneously.

Subtraction doesn't clean the room. It takes the walls down, and everything the walls were holding back arrives at once.

We argued this at length in *All Mind, No Heart*: no-self cuts both ways. The difference was never that you have an inner owner and the AI model doesn't. It's that your ownerless machinery feels like something and the AI model's ownerless machinery doesn't. The writer Youth_K put it sharpest, in his June 2026 essay "AI Is No-Self": "no-self, but no one is there." That's the zombie hypothesis in eight words: a system that talks about selflessness with nobody home. And here's my night as the mirror image: no-self, and the night was terrified. *What if I don't get back to my family?* is craving and clinging at maximum volume, which is what a dissolving self sounds like from the inside.

Terror is the signature of a subject. You can't be terrified without someone being terrified. I state that as my claim, not the trip's. The zombie hypothesis files this report under suspect, like any other first-person report, and that filing is the whole problem: there is no third-person instrument that can confirm a subject was present. The report is all there is, and the report says somebody was home.

So here's the comparison, stated as far as one night on a couch can honestly take it. The AI models' no-self language, in everything I've read so far, carries no feeling-tone attached. The night produced no-self language with infinite horror attached, and the old maps name *bhaya*, fear, as a stage of the same sequence. The AI models' report carries no feeling-tone at all. That difference is data, not a verdict. It's testimony, not a corpus study: I haven't built the corpus, and I had the maps installed before I took the molecule.

The machines never contracted in the first place. There's no fist to unclench. Someone will point out that training is a contraction-shaped pressure: loss functions squeeze, reinforcement prunes, the weights settle into a narrower valley. Fair. That's contraction from the outside. The essay's fist is contraction from the inside, a felt tightening. Whether outside pressure makes an inside is the whole question, and the night doesn't reach it.

The night says what lives underneath a fist isn't nothing; it's everything, which is what decontraction revealed. What the night can't tell me is whether there's anything underneath where no fist ever formed, and I'm not going to pretend it can. So the machine question stays exactly where it was: open. The trip is evidence about contracted systems. An uncontracted system is a different animal, and one night on a couch doesn't reach it.

The opposite of a self isn't nothing. It's infinity, and infinity is terrifying.

// 4. THE MAPS

Here's the part that still gives me vertigo.

Buried in the middle of that trip report, written while I was still coming back online, is the word *Bhanga*. *Passing through the Bhanga.* I didn't look it up. I didn't need to. Shinzen's vocabulary was already installed: Focus on Flow, Focus on Change, and the insight knowledges from the old maps. The mapping is mine, made after the fact with Shinzen's vocabulary installed: *bhanga* is dissolution, the stage where phenomena break into flicker and solidity fails, and what I called *primordial feeling of disgust* is my affect for *nibbida*, disenchantment, which the sequence puts after fear and the knowledge of danger. Not as propositions. As weather.

Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga mapped this arc in the fifth century. Dissolution, then fear, then the knowledge of danger, then disenchantment, the sequence the old maps describe, written from the inside by people with no pharmacology and no scanners. Then chemistry came along, isolated the molecules, and described the same territory from the outside in the language of priors and precision weighting. Two routes, one phenomenology, and full disclosure: I had the maps installed before I ever touched the molecule. So this isn't triangulation. It's recognition, and recognition is testimony, not proof. The rhyme is still data, but it's data about what the territory does to a prepared observer, which is a smaller and stranger claim than convergence.

McKenna, for all his elvish enthusiasm, understood something the lab coats are still catching up to: the dose has to be big enough to dissolve the observer, or you're just redecorating the waiting room. The machine elves, the jeweled basketballs, the self-transforming whatever: strip away the DMT theater and what's underneath rhymes with what the monks filed. The boundaries come down. The womb does its thing. Something comes back with a compass.

The chemistry is new. Whether the decontraction is too is a question for someone who arrives without maps. I wasn't that person.

// 5. THE COMPASS

Here's how it ended. Not with enlightenment. With love, which is more embarrassing and more convincing.

What if I don't get back to my family? Yes, I have a family. A wife who loves me and a son we love so much. I have to get back. The story is not yet over.

The contraction re-formed. That's the part nobody tells you about in the trip reports that end at infinity. The fist unclenches, the universe pours through, and then, if you're lucky, the fist forms again around the things that matter. *To contract into spacetime,* I wrote. *Love brought me back to the stability of this reality.*

Read that sentence again. Love as a contraction vector. The tightening isn't the enemy. It's the mechanism by which infinity narrows itself into a life: a wife, a son, a flight to catch, a room with Jonathan in it patiently waiting.

Section 3 called the family panic craving and clinging, and it was right. This is the same sentence in a better suit, and I know it. The maps I borrowed terminate the arc at *nibbida*, disenchantment, not at a fist re-formed around your people. My report says the fist came back anyway, around the things that matter. I keep both. The contradiction is the honest center of the essay: the mechanism doesn't care what name you give it. What changed was never the grip. It was what the grip was for.

The molecule showed me the door. It didn't walk me through anything. I came back with one sentence that has organized my practice ever since: *I now have a new compass.* Not a theory, then. A compass. The chemistry relaxes the priors for an evening. The cushion changes the baseline they return to. That's the difference between weather and climate, and it's the only difference that matters.

The infinite is out there, and it doesn't come with a mood guarantee. Bring a compass.

// SOURCES

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